

How the mighty fall

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The great Frankie Dettori, one of the most successful (3000-plus winners) and colourful jockeys has filed for bankruptcy, saying “I am saddened and embarrassed by this outcome and would advise others to take a stronger rein over their financial matters.” Despite the number of successful sportspeople who have ended up broke, it is not a subject discussed freely. Not many stars have a financial safety net post-career.

Mike Tyson, who made over 400 million dollars filed for bankruptcy in 2005. Golfer John Daly gambled away some \$57 million (he didn’t declare bankruptcy, though). Olympic figure skater Dorothy Hamill (‘America’s Sweetheart’) turned pro and earned millions. She declared bankruptcy in 1996.

Others in that depressing list include Tour de France champion and Olympic hero Sir Bradley Wiggins and Boris Becker. Some went broke without declaring bankruptcy, like heavyweight champion Leon Spinks. Some made a small amount back, like Tyson.

Research by XPro, a charity for ex-players, suggests that three out of five Premier League players — who earn an average of £30,000 per week — declare bankruptcy within five years of retirement. According to the *Sports Illustrated*, 78 percent of NFL players face serious financial hardships after retirement, 16 percent of them going bankrupt.

There are good reasons for this. Lack of education is one. Once the millions come in, so do conmen and



Troubled times: The great Frankie Dettori, one of the most successful (3000-plus winners) and colourful jockeys has filed for bankruptcy, saying “I am saddened and embarrassed by this outcome and would advise others to take a stronger rein over their financial matters.” AP

smooth-talking operators keen to separate an athlete from his money. ‘Advisers’ are treated by many athletes the way they treat coaches — as people with greater knowledge whose advice is unselfish and sound. Athletes carry self-belief as a major weapon crucial to reaching the top. Often they can’t understand how such a character trait does not convert into successful investments.

Careers in sport are short, even shorter at the highest level. The average premier league footballer might make more money in a week (or day) than some salaried people make in a year (or a lifetime), but lifestyles change, fantasy buys suddenly become necessities, and invariably there is a coterie of friends and relatives only too glad to help the athlete shed some of his wealth. Then there are divorces to deal with.

Not all athletes tread this path, obviously. Michael Jordan built up a billion-dollar company as did Magic Johnson, and more recently Serena Williams. Magic Johnson credits his success to investing in capable people rather than to the “wisdom” of family members and old friends.

“Bankruptcy is a major decision and its consequences will affect me for many years,” said Dettori, a name familiar even to those who don’t follow racing. The sheer exuberance he brought to his job, his manner of leaping off a horse and his ready smile set him apart. So too did his drugs bust and the fact that he survived his plane going up in flames (killing the pilot).

The highlight of his career came at Ascot in 1996 when he saddled all seven winners on a single race card. In the end, however, sadness — for both the star and his fans.